Research Frameworks Template Guide

Understanding Research Frameworks

Research frameworks provide the structural foundation for your study. They help organize your thinking, guide your methodology, and explain the relationships between variables and concepts in your research.

TYPES OF RESEARCH FRAMEWORKS

1. Conceptual Framework

A conceptual framework explains the key concepts, variables, and relationships that guide your research. It's your "mental model" of what you're studying.

2. Theoretical Framework

A theoretical framework applies existing theories to your research problem. It provides the lens through which you interpret your findings.

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK TEMPLATE

Components of a Conceptual Framework

Step 1: Identify Your Research Problem

Research Problem Statement:

[Clearly state the problem you're investigating]
Example: "Small business owners in Buea face challenges adopting mobile banking services, limiting their financial inclusion."

Step 2: Define Key Concepts

List and define all major concepts in your study:

Concept	Definition	How You'll Measure It
Mobile Banking Adoption	[Your definition]	Survey questions on usage frequency
Financial Inclusion	[Your definition]	Access to financial services score
Business Growth	[Your definition]	Revenue increase over 12 months

Step 3: Identify Variables

Independent Variables (IV): What you believe causes change

- Variable 1: _____
- Variable 2: _____
- Variable 3: _____

Dependent Variables (DV): What you believe will be affected

- Variable 1: _____
- Variable 2: _____

Moderating Variables: Factors that affect the strength of the relationship

- Variable 1: _____
- Variable 2: _____

Mediating Variables: Variables that explain how/why the effect occurs

- Variable 1: _____

Control Variables: Factors you want to keep constant

- Variable 1: _____
- Variable 2: _____

Step 4: Map Relationships

Create a visual diagram showing how variables relate:

```
[Independent Variable 1] ──────→ [Dependent Variable]
                         ↑
[Independent Variable 2] ──────────────┘
      ↓
[Mediating Variable]
      ↓
      └──────→ [Dependent Variable]

[Moderating Variable] affects the strength of relationships
```

Step 5: Explain Relationships

For each arrow in your diagram, explain the expected relationship:

Relationship 1: IV1 → DV

- **Nature:** Positive/Negative/Curvilinear
- **Justification:** Based on literature, we expect that as [IV1] increases, [DV] will [increase/decrease] because...

Relationship 2: IV2 → Mediator → DV

- **Nature:**
- **Justification:**

EXAMPLE: CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Research Topic:

"Impact of Mobile Banking on Small Business Growth in Buea"

Conceptual Framework Diagram:

```
INDEPENDENT VARIABLES          MEDIATING VARIABLE        DEPENDENT VARIABLE

┌──────────────────────┐
│ Mobile Banking       │
│ Adoption Rate        │──────┐
└──────────────────────┘      │
                              │   ┌──────────────────┐      ┌──────────────────┐
┌──────────────────────┐      │   │ Financial        │      │ Business         │
│ Ease of Use          │──────┼──────→│ Inclusion        │──────────→│ Growth           │
└──────────────────────┘      │   │ Level            │      └──────────────────┘
                              │   └──────────────────┘
┌──────────────────────┐      │
│ Digital Literacy     │──────┘
└──────────────────────┘

MODERATING VARIABLE:

┌──────────────────────┐
│ Business Size        │ (affects strength of all relationships)
└──────────────────────┘

CONTROL VARIABLES:
```

- Business sector
- Owner's age
- Years in business

Narrative Explanation:

This study proposes that mobile banking adoption, ease of use, and digital literacy (independent variables) influence business growth (dependent variable) through the mediating role of financial inclusion. We expect that businesses with higher mobile banking adoption will experience greater financial inclusion, which in turn leads to business growth. The relationship strength may vary based on business size (moderating variable).

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK TEMPLATE

Components of a Theoretical Framework

Step 1: Select Relevant Theory/Theories

Theory Name: _____ Originator(s): _____ Year: _____

Brief Summary: [Explain the theory in 2-3 sentences]

Key Propositions:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Step 2: Justify Theory Selection

Why this theory is appropriate for your study:

- Relevance: _____
- Previous applications: _____
- Explanatory power: _____

Step 3: Apply Theory to Your Research

How the theory explains your research problem: [Detailed explanation of how theoretical concepts map to your variables]

Step 4: Theory Limitations

Limitations or criticisms of the theory:

1. _____
2. _____

How you'll address these limitations:

_____

_____

EXAMPLE: THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

Research Topic:

"Technology Acceptance Among Small Business Owners"

Selected Theory:

Technology Acceptance Model (TAM)

- **Originators:** Fred Davis (1989)
- **Context:** Originally developed to explain computer usage behavior

Theory Components Applied to This Study:

TAM Construct	Definition	Application to Mobile Banking
Perceived Usefulness (PU)	Degree to which a person believes technology improves performance	Business owners' belief that mobile banking improves financial management
Perceived Ease of Use (PEOU)	Degree to which using technology is effort-free	How easy business owners find mobile banking interfaces
Attitude Toward Use	User's evaluation of technology	Overall sentiment toward mobile banking
Behavioral Intention	Intention to use technology	Plan to adopt/continue mobile banking
Actual Use	Real usage behavior	Frequency and types of mobile banking transactions

Theoretical Propositions for This Study:

1. H1: Perceived usefulness positively influences attitude toward mobile banking
2. H2: Perceived ease of use positively influences perceived usefulness
3. H3: Perceived ease of use positively influences attitude toward mobile banking

4. H4: Attitude positively influences behavioral intention to use mobile banking
5. H5: Behavioral intention positively influences actual mobile banking use

Extended TAM Model for This Study:

We extend TAM by adding context-specific variables:

- Trust in technology (additional external variable)
- Social influence from peer businesses (additional external variable)

FRAMEWORK DEVELOPMENT CHECKLIST

Conceptual Framework

- [ ] Clearly identified research problem
- [ ] All key concepts defined
- [ ] Variables categorized (IV, DV, moderating, mediating, control)
- [ ] Relationships between variables explained
- [ ] Visual diagram created
- [ ] Literature support for each relationship cited
- [ ] Framework aligned with research questions/hypotheses

Theoretical Framework

- [ ] Relevant theory/theories identified
- [ ] Theory's main propositions explained
- [ ] Justification for theory selection provided
- [ ] Theory applied to specific research context
- [ ] Theoretical constructs operationalized
- [ ] Hypotheses derived from theory
- [ ] Theory limitations acknowledged
- [ ] Gaps or extensions to theory noted

VISUAL FRAMEWORK EXAMPLES

Simple Linear Framework

```
A ──→ B ──→ C
(Clear cause-effect chain)
```

Multiple Independent Variables

```
A1 ──┐
A2 ──┼──→ B
A3 ──┘
```

Mediating Relationship

```
A ──→ M ──→ B
(A affects B through M)
```

Moderating Relationship

```
A ──→ B
↑
│
C (moderates the A→B relationship)
```

Complex Framework

```
      ┌──→ M1 ──┐
A1 ──┬──┴──┬──┴──┬──→ DV
  │  └──→ M2 ──┘    ↑
  │        │
A2 ──┤        │
  │    MV affects strength
A3 ──┘
```

WRITING YOUR FRAMEWORK SECTION

Introduction to Framework

Start with:

```
"This study is guided by a [conceptual/theoretical] framework that explains
the relationships between [key concepts]. The framework is based on
[theory name / literature synthesis] and proposes that..."
```

Describing Variables

For each variable:

> "[Variable name] is defined as [definition]. In this study, it is operationalized as [measurement approach]. Previous research by [Author, Year] found that [relevant finding]."

Explaining Relationships

For each relationship:

> "The framework proposes a [positive/negative/curvilinear] relationship between [Variable A] and [Variable B]. This relationship is expected because [theoretical justification]. [Author, Year] found similar patterns in [context]."

Concluding Framework Section

End with:

> "In summary, this framework provides the conceptual foundation for understanding how [phenomenon]. It guides the research design, measurement of variables, and interpretation of findings."

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

1. Too Complex

❌ Including every possible variable
✅ Focus on key relationships most relevant to your research questions

2. Lack of Literature Support

❌ Proposing relationships without citation
✅ Every relationship should be justified with literature

3. Mismatch with Methodology

❌ Conceptual framework suggests experiments but you're doing surveys
✅ Ensure framework aligns with your chosen methods

4. Unclear Definitions

❌ Using terms without defining them
✅ Clearly define all key concepts and variables

5. Static Framework

❌ Never revisiting the framework after data collection
✅ Reflect on framework in discussion section

FRAMEWORK DEVELOPMENT PROCESS

Stage 1: Preliminary (Weeks 1-2)

- Conduct initial literature review
- Identify key concepts
- Sketch rough relationships

Stage 2: Development (Weeks 3-4)

- Refine variable definitions
- Map detailed relationships
- Create visual diagram
- Get supervisor feedback

Stage 3: Refinement (Weeks 5-6)

- Revise based on feedback
- Ensure alignment with methodology
- Write detailed narrative
- Finalize diagram

Stage 4: Application (Throughout Study)

- Use framework to guide data collection
- Analyze data according to framework
- Interpret findings through framework lens
- Discuss confirmations and contradictions

RESOURCES FOR FRAMEWORK DEVELOPMENT

Recommended Reading

1. Miles, M. B., & Huberman, A. M. (1994). *Qualitative Data Analysis*
2. Creswell, J. W. (2013). *Research Design: Qualitative, Quantitative, and Mixed Methods Approaches*
3. Maxwell, J. A. (2013). *Qualitative Research Design: An Interactive Approach*

Online Tools

- **Draw.io**: Free diagramming tool
- **Lucidchart**: Professional diagram creation
- **Mind mapping software**: For brainstorming frameworks

Getting Help

- Discuss with supervisor regularly
- Present to research seminars for feedback
- Consult methodology textbooks in your discipline
- Review frameworks in published studies in your field

This template is designed for students and researchers developing conceptual and theoretical frameworks. Adapt it to your specific discipline and research context.

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